Chapter 1: Babur’s Home

1 In AD 1220, nearly all Central Asia and the territory of modern Kazakhstan were invaded by Mongols. There were no written documents about Taraz’s growth under the Mongols after they razed it to the ground. Remnants of fire found during the excavation show that the city was burnt. Probably the town was renamed as Yany (new); while mentioning it, European and Arabic sources write, ‘The city Yany, named Taraz before the conquest.’ Archaeological finds show that the once-lively city under the Mongolian yoke lost its previous significance and independence. Settled life in Taraz ended and the decline began. Under the Chagatayids (descendants of Chagatai Khān), coins were minted in Taraz until AD 1334. The Tsareviches, who, as Vasa of fourteenth century states, ‘Burnt the Golden Horde, destroyed Taraz and other cities, and killed the population. They took everything they could take and burnt the rest. There was a mention of the city again in AD 1345 in the road guidebook as a city laid on the trade route from Transoxiana to Almalyk.’ Steady internecine war in Central Asia interfered with the trade with distant countries, and the opening of the sea route from the Western European countries to India stopped the trade on the ancient silk road and led to the decline of the cities on this road.

2 The Syr Darya is a river located in Central Asia. The name has Persian origin which literally means Syr Sea or Syr River. A few people often referred to in this way. It originates in the Tian Shan Mountains of Kyrgyzstan and eastern Uzbekistan. Flowing 1,401.97 miles west it enters north-west through Uzbekistan and southern Kazakhstan. It finally ends in the northern remnants of the Aral Sea. It is among the two main rivers in the endorheic basin of the Aral Sea. The other important river is Amu Darya (Jayhun). During the Soviet era a tragedy was crafted. The extensive irrigation project of the Soviets came around both rivers, thereby diverting water into the farmlands. The effect did not show up immediately but in post-Soviet era, world’s fourth largest lake; Aral Sea virtually disappeared.

3 Fanākat was also known as Banākaṯ, Benākaṯ (not to be confused with another town of Benkaṯ, another town of Šāš, later to become Tashkent). It was the main town of the medieval Transoxiana province of Šāš or Čāč.

4 Although Banākaṯ flourished in early Islamic times, but it almost certainly had a pre-Islamic history as a center of the Sogdians. According to Markwart, Wehrot und Arang, (Leiden, 1938, pp. 162-63), the name derives from Middle Persian